

Refilled Cartridges

Trying to save that extra money by getting your toner cartridge refilled? Think twice! Is your machine out of warranty? If something goes wrong while using these refilled cartridges, how much will you need to pay for the repairs? Will the printer vendor support a printer that uses refilled cartridges? These are some of the question you would need to answer before you do use refilled cartridges.

We talked to technicians from some leading vendors in the laser printer market, like Hewlett-Packard, Lexmark and Epson about their opinion regarding using refilled cartridges. The answer was unanimous. All the technicians clearly said that they never recommend usage of refilled cartridges but admitted that many users do use refilled cartridges after expiry of warranty period. Here are some reasons why you should not use refilled cartridges:

1. The quality of the toner used is always low or not of the quality generally used in the original cartridge
2. The printer drivers have settings like density of toner, toner composition, etc that are meant for a particular type of toner. So if the quality or type of toner is wrong, print quality would suffer
3. During refilling, it is possible that the cartridge drum might get scratched or damaged, which would affect the smooth working of the printer
4. Improper sealing of the refilled cartridge could cause toner leakage when the printer is in use. If the toner falls into the printer's internals, serious problems could result.
5. These problems may not arise when you use the refilled cartridge for the first time, but they will invariably crop up after a while

is of great help while doing vector printing. The Lexmark Optra M412 is the only printer that comes with LCD management display. This display comes in handy for configuring the printer, especially when you use the network interface card.

The Samsung 6060N was the only printer that came with a 10/100 MBPS network interface card that would be useful if you have a small workgroup of machines. The Epson EPL 5800 has 16 MB of memory, upgradable to 256 MB, which is the highest in this category. Almost all the printers came with a 'toner save' feature. The Samsung ML 4600 has the toner saving button on top, which makes it easily accessible. The other printers too have the toner save mode but this has to be enabled via the printer drivers. When the printer is turned on and no tasks are given to it, the printer goes into sleep mode, cutting down on the electricity bills. This is a prominent feature of the Lexmark E312L.

The Samsung ML 6060N had the biggest paper tray—the input tray can hold a whopping 550 sheets of paper. These are some of the features we noticed in the printers. These features were logged and

Wipro was able to print the vector image but the image was too bright.

The Hewlett-Packard printers were able to print the vector image properly without much hindrances, probably because of the separate drivers provided for PostScript printing.

Text quality: This test brings out the printer's ability to print text using normal fonts in various sizes. This is very useful for users looking out for a midrange laser printer that would be normally used for printing documents, letters, etc. Well, here the **Hewlett-Packard LaserJet 1220Se** and the **LaserJet 1200** bagged the highest rating. The only weakness was found to be with the 1-point size printing where the characters seemed to overlap one another in two of the fonts used.

The Wipro Laser 1500 too recorded the same scores, but here the problem was noticed with 2-point size where the fonts appeared to be a bit hazy. The average scorer in this category is the Lexmark Optra M412, which printed till 3-point size but was a bit hazy at 2-point size and at 1-point size the character were found to be printed one on top of the other. The worst in the section was the Epson EPL 5800, which had lots of flaws in the print. The 2-point size

and the 1-point size character actually overlapped each other for two of the font types.

The rest of the printers were able to reproduce fonts up to 4-point size easily, but displayed problems with 3-point and 1-point size. The printer that you will need for printing text would be the Hewlett-Packard 1220Se and the LaserJet 1200.



SAMSUNG ML 6060-L:
Gave good text output

Features

Apart from speed and image quality, the other factor that makes for a good buy when it comes to laser printers is the presence of features such as the ability to print on different media (transparencies, different paper sizes, envelopes, etc). Are there features that improve print quality or make it easier to work with?

The HP printers head the list when it comes to availability of features. The Hewlett-Packard LaserJet 1220Se (which comes with the scanner assembly as standard equipment) is at the top. The other HP LaserJet 1200 series does have an option for a scanner-cum-copier but this assembly doesn't come as standard equipment. The HP printers come with the separate drivers for PostScript printing, which

Using Different Media

Laser printers are popularly used for document printing, but did you know that you could use the same printers to print on different media? A normal laser printer would be able to support printing on various types of media: plain paper, transparencies, card paper, labels, etc. These papers too come in different sizes like A3, A4, A5, B4, B5, ledger, letter, legal, recycled paper, card stock, labels, envelopes etc. Printers may have to be physically adjusted to accept some type of media like envelopes.

Remember that printer manufacturers have their own branded paper types that they recommend for use. Not all printers are compatible with all types of paper. The right place to verify this is the printer's manual, where the manufacturer clearly specifies the type of media the printer can handle. This can help you avoid unwanted headaches. If a certain printer does not support transparencies or label printing and if a person uses this printer to print on such media, he might damage the printer fuser or even the printer mechanism.